

Excel, and even Windows in general, use the following formats in handling dates:

- dd displays the date in numeric format
- ddd displays the day limited to the first three letters
- dddd displays the full word of the day
- mm displays the month in numeric format
- mmm displays the month in words limited to the first three letters
- mmmm displays the full word for the month
- yy displays the year in two digit format
- yyyy displays the year in four digit format
- hh displays the hour
- mm displays the minutes unless the context makes it refer to month
- ss displays the seconds

Thus a custom format of the type

ddd, dd/mm/yyyy hh:mm:ss AM/PM

will display the date and time 12th May, 2006 7:18 PM and 34 seconds in the following manner:

Fri, 12/05/2006 07:18:34 PM

If you omit the AM/PM, then the time will be displayed in 24-hour format irrespective of how it is entered. Also note that you need not enter the day. You just enter the date and time and Excel will automatically pick up the correct day. Similarly, if you leave out the time, Excel will assume it is 00:00 (midnight). Also, if you leave out the year, Excel will assume you are talking about the current year. Thus, for the above format, if you wanted to enter 6 February 2007 with no reference to the time, you could simply enter 6/2 or 6 Feb. Excel will automatically apply the above date format and display: